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1991–2008: Liberalization and US Unipolarity

The Year of Change, 1991

India experienced several fundamental changes in and around 1991 that sharply altered its international environment, its economy, its domestic politics, and its national security. These developments could perhaps be traced to three military interventions. The first was India's intervention in Sri Lanka after 1987 against Velupillai Prabhakaran and his Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE). Despite the withdrawal of Indian Peace Keeping Forces (IPKF) in 1990, the assassination of former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi by the LTTE during the campaign for the 1991 general elections created a political vacuum at the Centre in New Delhi. After elections that year, P.V. Narasimha Rao, an improbable candidate, became India's prime minister for the next five years. [1]

A second military intervention that left a lasting impact was the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan somewhat earlier in December 1979. What followed was a ruinous war waged by the Soviet Army against Afghan *mujahideen* backed by the United States, Pakistan, and Saudi Arabia. [2] The Soviet misadventure in Afghanistan contributed indirectly to political developments in Moscow with unforeseen results. In August 1991, a failed coup in the Soviet Union against Mikhail Gorbachev resulted in the dissolution of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union. The collapse of the USSR was quite sudden and relatively peaceful, a result of factionalism, failed reform, economic malaise, and the attractiveness of the Western economic, social, and political model. In the previous two years, from 1989 to 1991, the USSR had lost much of its influence in Central and Eastern Europe. By the end of 1991, fourteen new post-Soviet countries emerged in